Sharma, their legacy as coach and captain will be decided based on where India finishes this World Cup," batting legend and 1983 World Cup winner Sunil Gavaskar told INDIA TODAY.

DANGERS AHEAD

How often have we heard lines like: 'Never write off New Zealand in an ICC tournament', 'Pakistan is always dangerous', and 'Underestimate South Africa at your own peril'. Yet, beyond these challenges, the two biggest threats for India will come in the form of Australia and England. England's approach in red-ball cricket has fetched them much attention. Termed 'Bazball'—named after their Test coach Brendon McCullum—it's essentially ODI-style batting where batsmen maintain a healthy strike rate by going after the bowlers and forcing captains to spread the field (imagine multiple Virender Sehwags in a single batting line-up if you will). Yet, it's how England have played white-ball cricket that's transforming the sport. The results bear testimony to this: England are the ODI and T20 world champions, but are yet to play a WTC final and last won the Ashes in 2015.

THE TWO BIG THREATS FOR INDIA WILL BE AUSTRALIA AND ENGLAND, BOTH MASTERS OF THE FEARLESS, ATTACKING GAME

What's worked for the Three Lions has been their fearless approach—no matter the match situation, irrespective of the wickets down, the English batters never seem to curb their attacking instincts. Ditto for Australia. Of course, it's their rich reservoir of multi-faceted players that allows these two teams to bat as deep as they do. In turn, it affords them the luxury of going hammer and tongs right through their batting innings. Compare that to a team like India, which is scampering for a spin-bowling all-rounder just days ahead of the Cup. Injury to Axar Patel has resulted in the team going back to a 37-year-old Ashwin, who before his recall for the home series versus Australia hadn't played an ODI match for 20 months. The difference couldn't be starker. For India to repeat the heroics of 1983 and 2011, a lot will depend on factors beyond cricketing logic. Late evening dew in October-November makes winning the toss crucial. Add to that the luck factor—the odd run-out, a dropped catch, untimely rain interruptions. Without the rub of the green going their way, no team is guaranteed success. It's these glorious uncertainties that make the Cricket World Cup one of the greatest sports spectacles on Earth. ■

Nikhil Naz is Consulting Editor, Sports, India Today TV

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR



GETTY IMAGES

GLENN MAXWELL
AUSTRALIA
A mercurial player who can change the course of a game in mere overs. The unorthodox batting style can disturb a bowler's rhythm. IPL seasoning is another danger

JOS BUTTLER
ENGLAND
The England captain has delivered a World Cup (T20) for his country and now has to shoulder the expectations of being a favourite. One of the most dangerous batsmen playing currently

AP

– Player profiles by **Rahul Rawat**